at the outset. From the time he bested K.C. Venugopal in a bruising contest, he has been shadowed by talk that it was the outcome of muscle-flexing by one constituent of the United Democratic Front (UDF)—the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML).

Spawned by the BJP, fanned by national media, opportunistically joined at times by even the embittered Left, the collective word of the Opposition has sought to fix that victory in the public mind as proof that the Congress in Kerala—Satheesan in particular—is captive to a "Muslim party". In response, he chose not to be cowed down, mask that relationship, or diminish it in stature. Instead, he doubled down on it, describing the League as a sibling within the UDF. Then, he dared to back that with actual collateral.

Takeaways

- **Satheesan ministry takes in five IUML faces**
- **BJP, Left had taunted him as Muslim-propped**
- **ASHA, anganwadi workers wages hiked**

DELICATE DEMOCRACY

The May 18 oath-taking ceremony, at Thiruvananthapuram's Central Stadium, was a euphoric moment for the Congress, marked by gestures of civility. Following on from Vijay in Tamil Nadu, Satheesan had extended invitations to Opposition leaders. So Pinarayi was there, as was state BJP chief Rajeev Chandrashekhar. Words affirming democracy were spoken by all.

The 20-member cabinet was a mix of pragmatic choices, meeting the demands of other allies as well as settle Congress factional egos. Ramesh Chennithala, Satheesan's senior and the only other serious contender for CM, had been persuaded to soften up and sign on.

THE IUML IMPRINT

But civility wasn't much in evidence on the lips of Satheesan-baiters on something else: on the dais there also appeared five IUML figures who took the oath, led by its national general secretary P.K. Kunhalikutty.

That this offered a striking contrast to the national situation could not be overstated: excluding Jammu & Kashmir, the ratios of Muslims holding ministerial berths would plummet to the low single digits. Here, they formed a clear quarter of the present cabinet, a healthier percentage than even the 22 MLAs the IUML contributes to the 102-seat UDF.

Satheesan was indeed backed by the IUML. But he also had the trust of the Congress rank and file as well as other UDF allies. The average voter, too, observers point out, largely swung towards the straight-talking 61-year-old from Paravur as their alternative. But a few sour notes are already appearing. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge was apparently miffed at backward castes and Dalits not getting enough due in the 'inclusive' cabinet. So is the Church, but over IUML bagging the education and fisheries portfolios.

For sure, the Muslim association has stood out in an India where that itself often passes for a taint. Especially since the book-loving CM—a photo of his shows him reading Yanis Varoufakis's *Technofeudalism*—combines that with a capacity to keep the local feudal lords at an arm's distance. Here was a Nair who tells the Nair Service Society—and other caste sabhas—that they do not get free tickets on his bus. ■

ODISHA

Majhi Puts on Tough Sheriff Hat

The state cracks down on crime with a state-wide special drive against all manner of offenders

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

DID SOMEONE SAY MOHAN CHARAN MAJHI was a chief minister with little demonstrable administrative will of his own? Perish the thought. For, Odisha's unassuming chief minister has put his signature on one of the toughest crackdowns on crime the state has seen yet. Its scale is truly one for the books. Within the span of a five-day special drive, from May 12 to May 16, over 1,700 alleged culprits found themselves in the cooler through the execution of non-bailable warrants.

It was after Majhi publicly raised concerns over rising violent crime in Odisha that police went into action. The operation, ordered by DGP Yogesh



ARABINDA MAHAPATRA

NIGHT OPERATION Police with a seized truck used in illegal mining in Balasore, Odisha, May 14